

: Interview Summary

Q1. When do you usually experience the most stress during the semester?

The participant explained that stress mainly occurs when facing assignments with unclear requirements or when lacking sufficient knowledge to complete them. Since the Media Informatik master's program involves a significant amount of self-learning, uncertainty about whether they are learning the "right" skills creates additional pressure.

Beyond assignment deadlines, the participant also experiences **long-term stress** throughout the entire study program. They constantly question whether they are learning enough and whether their current progress will be sufficient to secure employment after graduation.

Another major source of stress is **perfectionism**. The participant tries to fully master every new technology or skill introduced during coursework before completing assignments. For example, instead of using AI to quickly generate a landing page, they preferred learning Framer from scratch because they wanted to understand the technology themselves. This often increases both workload and stress.

The participant also mentioned that the rapid development of AI has created an additional dilemma. Although AI could significantly reduce the time required for assignments, they feel uncomfortable relying on it because they first want to build a strong foundation of knowledge independently.

Q2. How do you usually cope with stress?

The participant described several coping strategies that they currently use.

The most effective approach is adopting a **"just do it" mindset**, which helps them avoid overthinking and begin working on tasks immediately.

They also intentionally **change their study environment**, for example by studying in the university library instead of at home, where there are fewer distractions and it is easier to stay focused.

Another helpful strategy is reminding themselves that **an assignment does not have to be perfect**. Accepting that mistakes are part of the learning process helps reduce pressure.

Other positive coping mechanisms include taking short breaks, exercising, drinking tea, cooking, and occasionally using AI more efficiently when learning everything from scratch becomes overwhelming.

The participant noted that activities such as gaming, listening to music, or playing the guitar provide temporary enjoyment but often lead to feelings of guilt afterwards because they delay completing academic work. They also recognized that perfectionism and low self-confidence contribute to procrastination, creating a cycle of increased stress.

Q3. Have you ever used a mental health or well-being application?

The participant had not previously used any dedicated mental health or well-being application. Instead, they had used **generative AI tools such as ChatGPT and Claude** to seek advice about stress and personal concerns.

However, they found these experiences largely unsatisfactory. The responses were perceived as **too general**, lacking personalization and often resembling generic motivational messages found on social media. Although the participant expected scientifically grounded advice that addressed their specific situation, the AI-generated responses were considered too simplistic and not particularly helpful.

The participant concluded that existing AI tools are useful for obtaining general recommendations

but are currently not able to provide the level of personalized and meaningful support that a professional therapist can offer.